# Guitar Chord Reference

A Comprehensive Visual Guide  Standard Tuning: E – A – D – G – B – e

Theory (A – G) · Open chords · Barre chords · 7ths · Sus · Power · Add9 · Aug · Dim

This guide is a self-contained reference for guitarists at any level, from the first open chord to complex jazz voicings. It is organised in three parts.

The **theory chapter** (pages 3–11) explains how chord symbols work: what the letters and suffixes mean, and how every chord type is built from a scale. Each of the seven natural roots (A through G) gets its own table, with close-position staff notation in the treble-8 clef standard to guitar.

The **chord diagram sections** (pages 12–16) provide fingering diagrams and staff notation for more than sixty voicings in standard tuning: open major and minor chords, dominant and major seventh chords, suspended, power, barre, add9, augmented and diminished chords, and the diatonic chords of C major, with the Roman numerals that transpose any progression to a new key.

The **practical sections** (pages 16–19) bridge theory and playing: a primer on strumming patterns and rhythm notation, four graded songs (beginner to intermediate) with chord grids and picking patterns, and a set of technique tips for cleaner fretting, smoother chord changes and better barre chords.

All diagrams assume **standard tuning** (low to high: E – A – D – G – B – e). Staff notation uses the **treble-8 clef** (sounds one octave below written), which is the international standard for guitar.

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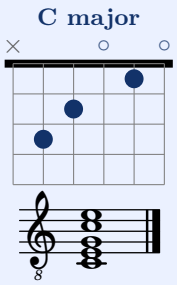
## How to Read Chord Diagrams

Each diagram shows the guitar neck as seen from the front. Strings are **vertical** (low E at left, high e at right); frets are **horizontal**.

- **Thick top bar** = the nut (open-position chords)
- **Number at left** = starting fret (chords played higher up the neck)
- **Filled circles** = press here with your fingertip
- **Thick round bar** = barre (one finger across multiple strings)
- ○ above string = play it *open* (unfretted)
- × above string = mute / do not play

The **staff notation** below each diagram uses the *treble-8* clef — standard for guitar. Notes are written an octave higher than they sound; the "8" below the clef is a reminder to read them down one octave. Finger numbers: **1**=index **2**=middle **3**=ring **4**=pinky.

*Example: C major (x32010)*
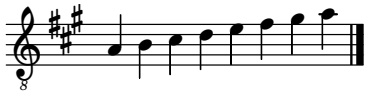



## Chord Theory: Chord Families A through G
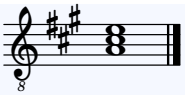
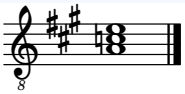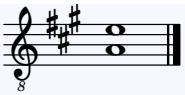
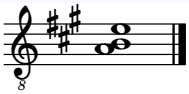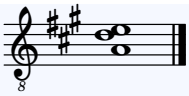
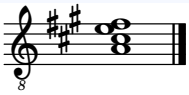
A chord symbol has two parts: a **root** (the letter name) and a **quality descriptor** that specifies the interval structure. The tables below show every chord type for each of the seven natural roots **A, B, C, D, E, F, G**. Formulas use *scale-degree numbers* with accidentals (♭ = lower by 1 semitone, ♯ = raise by 1 semitone). The **Staff** column shows the chord in close position using the treble-8 clef; guitar diagrams on later pages show practical voicings on the fretboard.
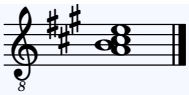
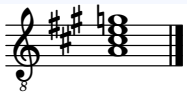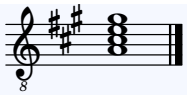
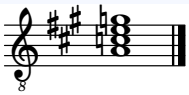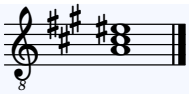
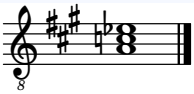
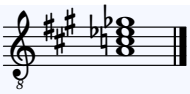
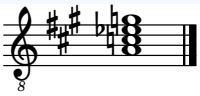
### The A Family

**Key signature:** three sharps: F♯, C♯, G♯.
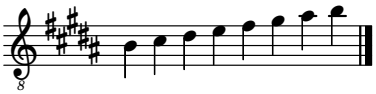


**1** A **2** B **3** C♯ **4** D **5** E **6** F♯ **7** G♯ **8** A

| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **A** | A major | 1 – 3 – 5 |  | Bright, stable. |
| **Am** | A minor | 1 – ♭3 – 5 |  | Dark. Lower the 3rd: C♯ → C. |
| **A5** | A power chord | 1 – 5 |  | Raw, neutral. No 3rd. |
| **Asus2** | A sus. 2nd | 1 – 2 – 5 |  | Open. Replace 3rd with 2nd (B). |
| **Asus4** | A sus. 4th | 1 – 4 – 5 |  | Tense. Replace 3rd with 4th (D). |
| **A6** | A major sixth | 1 – 3 – 5 – 6 |  | Sweet, vintage. Add 6th (F♯). |
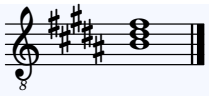
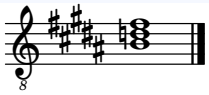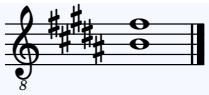
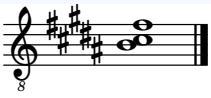
| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Aadd9** | A add nine | 1 – 3 – 5 – 9 |  | Colourful. Add 2nd/9th (B), no 7th. |
| **A7** | A dominant 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Bluesy. Lower 7th: G♯ → G. |
| **Amaj7** | A major 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – 7 |  | Dreamy, jazzy. Keep natural 7th (G♯). |
| **Am7** | A minor 7th | 1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Mellow, soulful. Lower 3rd and 7th. |
| **Aaug** | A augmented | 1 – 3 – ♯5 |  | Eerie. Raise the 5th by 1 semitone. |
| **Adim** | A diminished | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 |  | Very tense. Lower 3rd and 5th. |
| **Adim7** | A dim. 7th | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭♭7 |  | Max. tense. All minor 3rds. |
| **Am7♭5** | A half-dim. | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭7 |  | Tense, jazzy (also: Aø). |
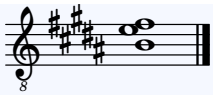
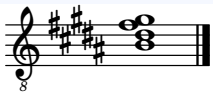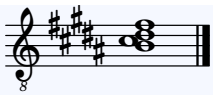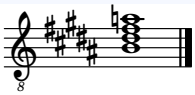
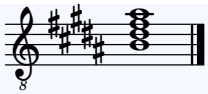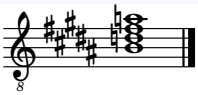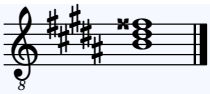
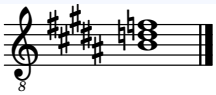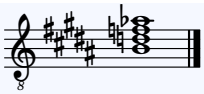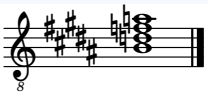
### The B Family

**Key signature:** five sharps: F♯, C♯, G♯, D♯, A♯.
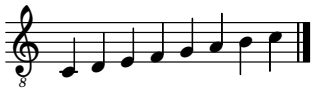


**1** B **2** C♯ **3** D♯ **4** E **5** F♯ **6** G♯ **7** A♯ **8** B

| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **B** | B major | 1 – 3 – 5 |  | Bright, stable. |
| **Bm** | B minor | 1 – ♭3 – 5 |  | Dark. Lower the 3rd: D♯ → D. |
| **B5** | B power chord | 1 – 5 |  | Raw, neutral. No 3rd. |
| **Bsus2** | B sus. 2nd | 1 – 2 – 5 |  | Open. Replace 3rd with 2nd (C♯). |
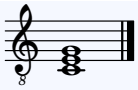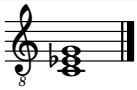
| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Bsus4** | B sus. 4th | 1 – 4 – 5 |  | Tense. Replace 3rd with 4th (E). |
| **B6** | B major sixth | 1 – 3 – 5 – 6 |  | Sweet, vintage. Add 6th (G♯). |
| **Badd9** | B add nine | 1 – 3 – 5 – 9 |  | Colourful. Add 2nd/9th (C♯), no 7th. |
| **B7** | B dominant 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Bluesy. Lower 7th: A♯ → A. |
| **Bmaj7** | B major 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – 7 |  | Dreamy, jazzy. Keep natural 7th (A♯). |
| **Bm7** | B minor 7th | 1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Mellow, soulful. Lower 3rd and 7th. |
| **Baug** | B augmented | 1 – 3 – ♯5 |  | Eerie. Raise the 5th by 1 semitone. |
| **Bdim** | B diminished | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 |  | Very tense. Lower 3rd and 5th. |
| **Bdim7** | B dim. 7th | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – 𝄫7 |  | Max. tense. All minor 3rds. |
| **Bm7♭5** | B half-dim. | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭7 |  | Tense, jazzy (also: Bø). |
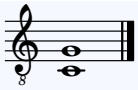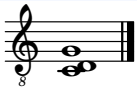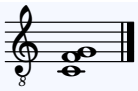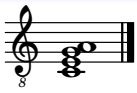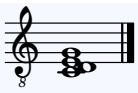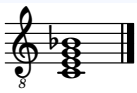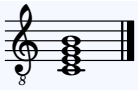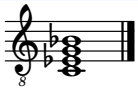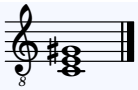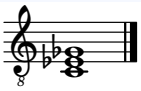
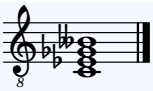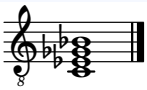
### The C Family

**Key signature:** no sharps or flats.
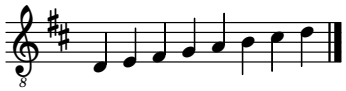


**1** C **2** D **3** E **4** F **5** G **6** A **7** B **8** C

| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **C** | C major | 1 – 3 – 5 |  | Bright, stable. |
| **Cm** | C minor | 1 – ♭3 – 5 |  | Dark. Lower the 3rd: E → E♭. |
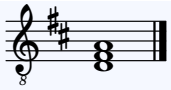
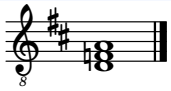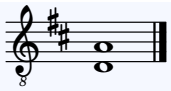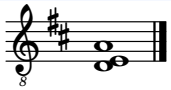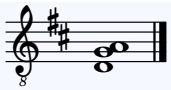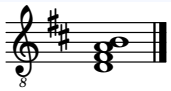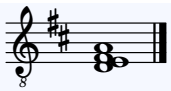
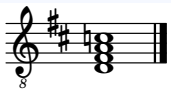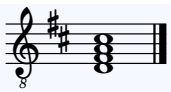
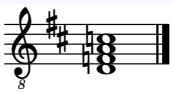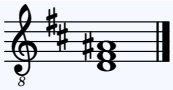
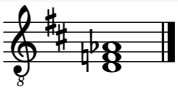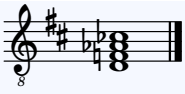
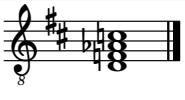
| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **C5** | C power chord | 1 – 5 |  | Raw, neutral. No 3rd. |
| **Csus2** | C sus. 2nd | 1 – 2 – 5 |  | Open. Replace 3rd with 2nd (D). |
| **Csus4** | C sus. 4th | 1 – 4 – 5 |  | Tense. Replace 3rd with 4th (F). |
| **C6** | C major sixth | 1 – 3 – 5 – 6 |  | Sweet, vintage. Add 6th (A). |
| **Cadd9** | C add nine | 1 – 3 – 5 – 9 |  | Colourful. Add 2nd/9th (D), no 7th. |
| **C7** | C dominant 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Bluesy. Lower 7th: B → B♭. |
| **Cmaj7** | C major 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – 7 |  | Dreamy, jazzy. Keep natural 7th (B). |
| **Cm7** | C minor 7th | 1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Mellow, soulful. Lower 3rd and 7th. |
| **Caug** | C augmented | 1 – 3 – ♯5 |  | Eerie. Raise the 5th by 1 semitone. |
| **Cdim** | C diminished | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 |  | Very tense. Lower 3rd and 5th. |
| **Cdim7** | C dim. 7th | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭♭7 |  | Max. tense. All minor 3rds. |
| **Cm7♭5** | C half-dim. | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭7 |  | Tense, jazzy (also: Cø). |

### The D Family

**Key signature:** two sharps: F♯, C♯.
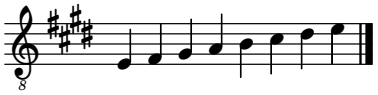


**1** D **2** E **3** F♯ **4** G **5** A **6** B **7** C♯ **8** D
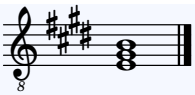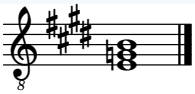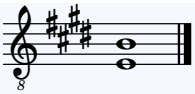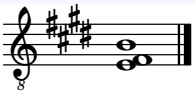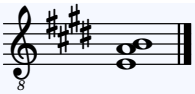
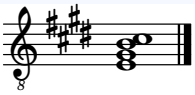
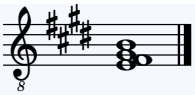
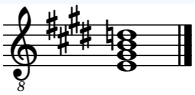
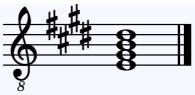
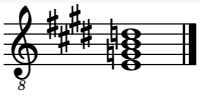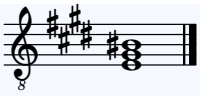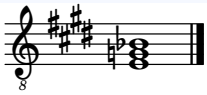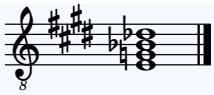
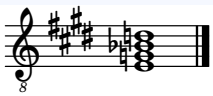
| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **D** | D major | 1 – 3 – 5 |  | Bright, stable. |
| **Dm** | D minor | 1 – ♭3 – 5 |  | Dark. Lower the 3rd: F♯ → F. |
| **D5** | D power chord | 1 – 5 |  | Raw, neutral. No 3rd. |
| **Dsus2** | D sus. 2nd | 1 – 2 – 5 |  | Open. Replace 3rd with 2nd (E). |
| **Dsus4** | D sus. 4th | 1 – 4 – 5 |  | Tense. Replace 3rd with 4th (G). |
| **D6** | D major sixth | 1 – 3 – 5 – 6 |  | Sweet, vintage. Add 6th (B). |
| **Dadd9** | D add nine | 1 – 3 – 5 – 9 |  | Colourful. Add 2nd/9th (E), no 7th. |
| **D7** | D dominant 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Bluesy. Lower 7th: C♯ → C. |
| **Dmaj7** | D major 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – 7 |  | Dreamy, jazzy. Keep natural 7th (C♯). |
| **Dm7** | D minor 7th | 1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Mellow, soulful. Lower 3rd and 7th. |
| **Daug** | D augmented | 1 – 3 – ♯5 |  | Eerie. Raise the 5th by 1 semitone. |
| **Ddim** | D diminished | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 |  | Very tense. Lower 3rd and 5th. |
| **Ddim7** | D dim. 7th | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭♭7 |  | Max. tense. All minor 3rds. |
| **Dm7♭5** | D half-dim. | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭7 |  | Tense, jazzy (also: Dø). |

### The E Family

**Key signature:** four sharps: F♯, C♯, G♯, D♯.
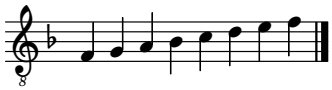


**1** E **2** F♯ **3** G♯ **4** A **5** B **6** C♯ **7** D♯ **8** E

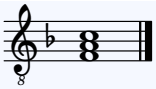
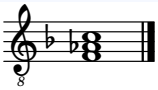
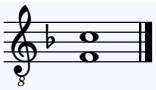
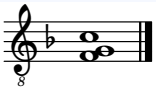
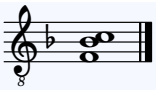
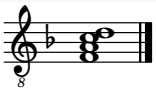
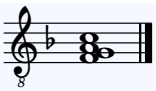
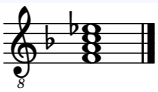
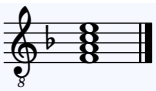
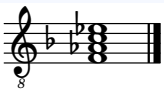
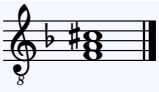
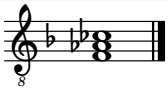
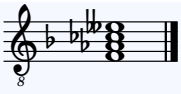
| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **E** | E major | 1 – 3 – 5 |  | Bright, stable. |
| **Em** | E minor | 1 – ♭3 – 5 |  | Dark. Lower the 3rd: G♯ → G. |
| **E5** | E power chord | 1 – 5 |  | Raw, neutral. No 3rd. |
| **Esus2** | E sus. 2nd | 1 – 2 – 5 |  | Open. Replace 3rd with 2nd (F♯). |
| **Esus4** | E sus. 4th | 1 – 4 – 5 |  | Tense. Replace 3rd with 4th (A). |
| **E6** | E major sixth | 1 – 3 – 5 – 6 |  | Sweet, vintage. Add 6th (C♯). |
| **Eadd9** | E add nine | 1 – 3 – 5 – 9 |  | Colourful. Add 2nd/9th (F♯), no 7th. |
| **E7** | E dominant 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Bluesy. Lower 7th: D♯ → D. |
| **Emaj7** | E major 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – 7 |  | Dreamy, jazzy. Keep natural 7th (D♯). |
| **Em7** | E minor 7th | 1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Mellow, soulful. Lower 3rd and 7th. |
| **Eaug** | E augmented | 1 – 3 – ♯5 |  | Eerie. Raise the 5th by 1 semitone. |
| **Edim** | E diminished | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 |  | Very tense. Lower 3rd and 5th. |
| **Edim7** | E dim. 7th | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭♭7 |  | Max. tense. All minor 3rds. |
| **Em7♭5** | E half-dim. | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭7 |  | Tense, jazzy (also: Eø). |
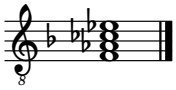
### The F Family

**Key signature:** one flat: B♭.
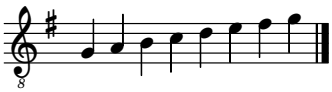


**1** F **2** G **3** A **4** B♭ **5** C **6** D **7** E **8** F

| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **F** | F major | 1 – 3 – 5 |  | Bright, stable. |
| **Fm** | F minor | 1 – ♭3 – 5 |  | Dark. Lower the 3rd: A → A♭. |
| **F5** | F power chord | 1 – 5 |  | Raw, neutral. No 3rd. |
| **Fsus2** | F sus. 2nd | 1 – 2 – 5 |  | Open. Replace 3rd with 2nd (G). |
| **Fsus4** | F sus. 4th | 1 – 4 – 5 |  | Tense. Replace 3rd with 4th (B♭). |
| **F6** | F major sixth | 1 – 3 – 5 – 6 |  | Sweet, vintage. Add 6th (D). |
| **Fadd9** | F add nine | 1 – 3 – 5 – 9 |  | Colourful. Add 2nd/9th (G), no 7th. |
| **F7** | F dominant 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Bluesy. Lower 7th: E → E♭. |
| **Fmaj7** | F major 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – 7 |  | Dreamy, jazzy. Keep natural 7th (E). |
| **Fm7** | F minor 7th | 1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Mellow, soulful. Lower 3rd and 7th. |
| **Faug** | F augmented | 1 – 3 – ♯5 |  | Eerie. Raise the 5th by 1 semitone. |
| **Fdim** | F diminished | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 |  | Very tense. Lower 3rd and 5th. |
| **Fdim7** | F dim. 7th | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭♭7 |  | Max. tense. All minor 3rds. |

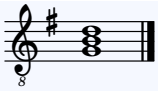
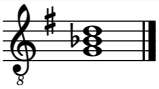
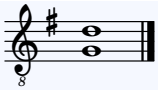
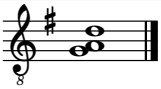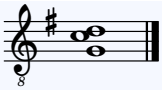
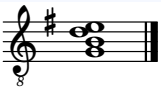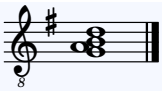
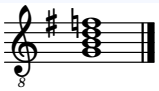
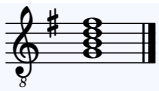
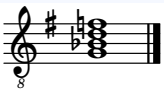
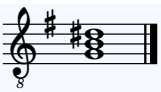
| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Fm7♭5** | F half-dim. | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭7 |  | Tense, jazzy (also: Fø). |
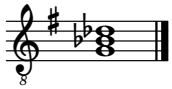
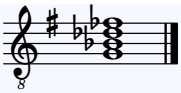
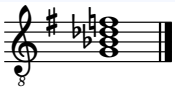
### The G Family

**Key signature:** one sharp: F♯.

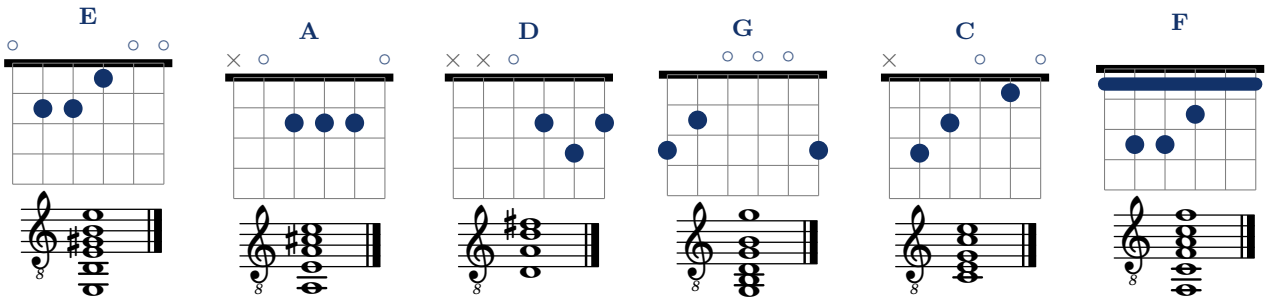


**1** G **2** A **3** B **4** C **5** D **6** E **7** F♯ **8** G

| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **G** | G major | 1 – 3 – 5 |  | Bright, stable. |
| **Gm** | G minor | 1 – ♭3 – 5 |  | Dark. Lower the 3rd: B → B♭. |
| **G5** | G power chord | 1 – 5 |  | Raw, neutral. No 3rd. |
| **Gsus2** | G sus. 2nd | 1 – 2 – 5 |  | Open. Replace 3rd with 2nd (A). |
| **Gsus4** | G sus. 4th | 1 – 4 – 5 |  | Tense. Replace 3rd with 4th (C). |
| **G6** | G major sixth | 1 – 3 – 5 – 6 |  | Sweet, vintage. Add 6th (E). |
| **Gadd9** | G add nine | 1 – 3 – 5 – 9 |  | Colourful. Add 2nd/9th (A), no 7th. |
| **G7** | G dominant 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Bluesy. Lower 7th: F♯ → F. |
| **Gmaj7** | G major 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – 7 |  | Dreamy, jazzy. Keep natural 7th (F♯). |
| **Gm7** | G minor 7th | 1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 |  | Mellow, soulful. Lower 3rd and 7th. |
| **Gaug** | G augmented | 1 – 3 – ♯5 |  | Eerie. Raise the 5th by 1 semitone. |

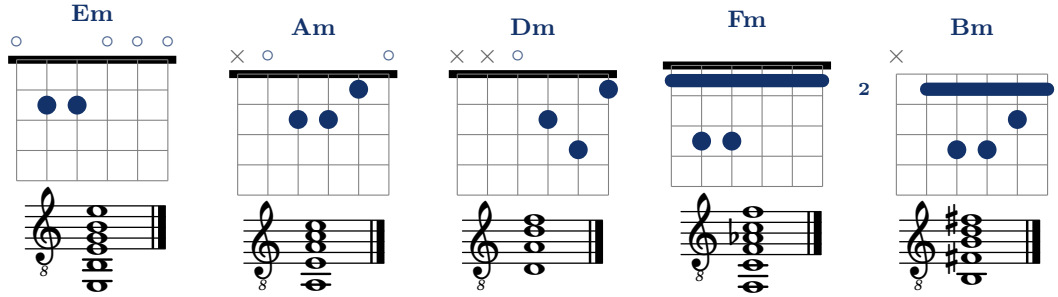
| Symbol | Full name | Formula | Staff | Colour / use |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Gdim** | G diminished | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 |  | Very tense. Lower 3rd and 5th. |
| **Gdim7** | G dim. 7th | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭♭7 |  | Max. tense. All minor 3rds. |
| **Gm7♭5** | G half-dim. | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭7 |  | Tense, jazzy (also: Gø). |

## Open-Position Major Chords




**E** 022100 **A** x02220 **D** xx0232 **G** 320003 **C** x32010 **F** 133211 (barre at fret 1)

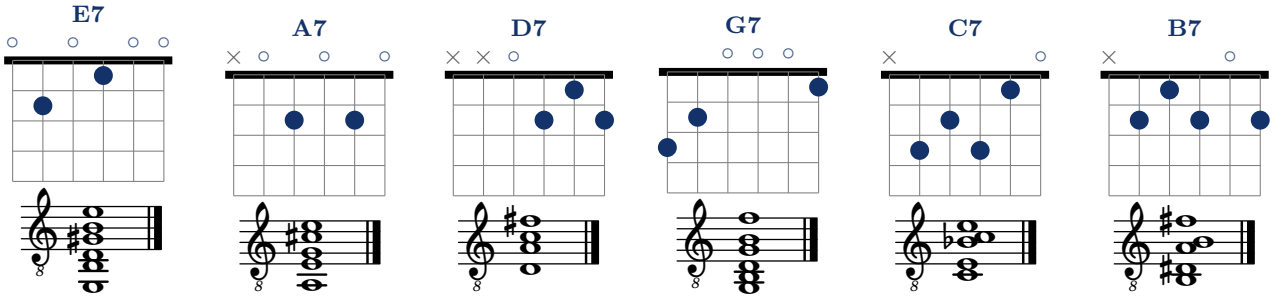
## Open-Position Minor Chords




**Em** 022000 **Am** x02210 **Dm** xx0231 **Fm** 133111 (barre at 1) **Bm** x24432 (barre at 2)

## Dominant 7th Chords

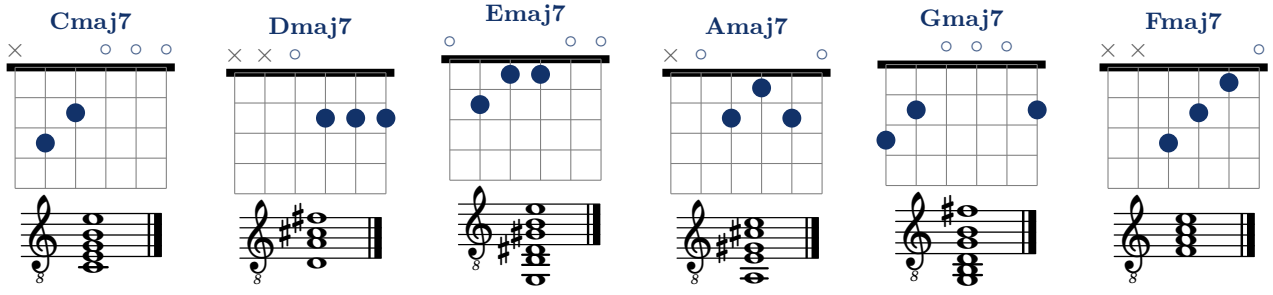
1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7: bluesy and tense, naturally resolving to the tonic.




**E7** 020100 **A7** x02020 **D7** xx0212 **G7** 320001 **C7** x32310 **B7** x21202

## Major 7th Chords (maj7)

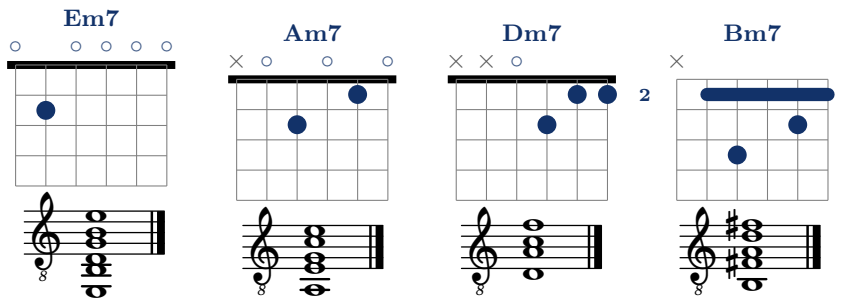
1 – 3 – 5 – 7: smooth, dreamy and jazzy.




**Cmaj7** x32000 **Dmaj7** xx0222 **Emaj7** 021100 **Amaj7** x02120 **Gmaj7** 320002 **Fmaj7** xx3210

## Minor 7th Chords (m7)

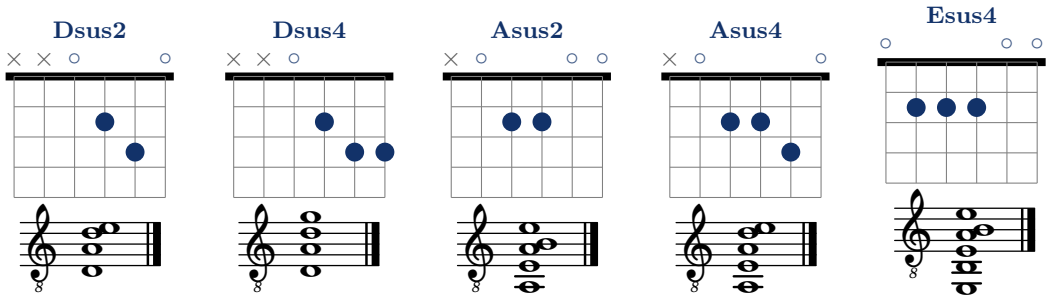
1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7: cornerstone of jazz, soul and R&B.




**Em7** 020000 **Am7** x02010 **Dm7** xx0211 **Bm7** x24232 (barre at 2, variant shown)

## Suspended Chords (sus2, sus4)

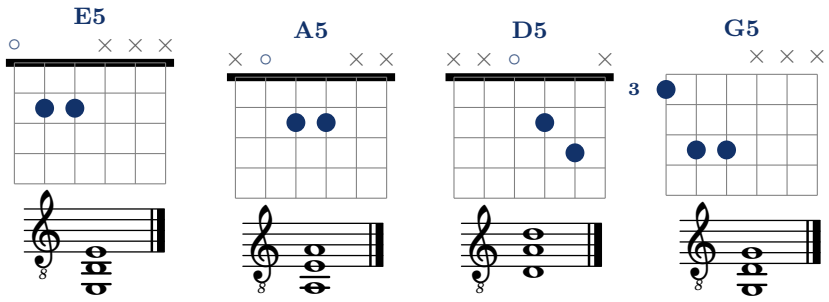
The 3rd is replaced by a 2nd or 4th: harmony is open and unresolved.




**Dsus2** xx0230 **Dsus4** xx0233 **Asus2** x02200 **Asus4** x02230 **Esus4** 022200

## Power Chords (5th Chords)

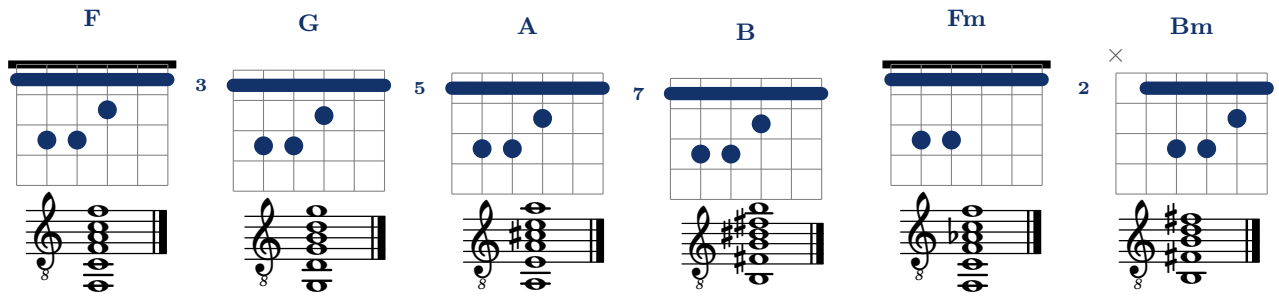
1 – 5 only, no 3rd: neither major nor minor. Essential in rock and metal.




**E5** 022xxx **A5** x022xx **D5** xx023x **G5** 355xxx (movable E5-shape at fret 3)

## Barre Chords — E Shape (Major and Minor)

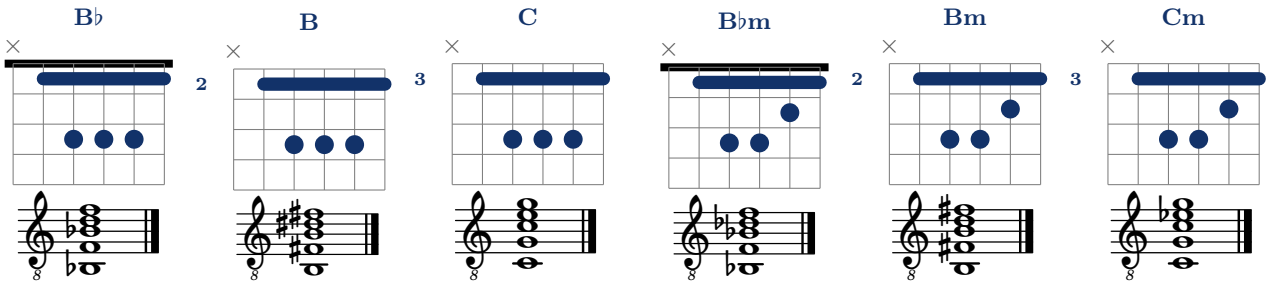
Open E or Em shape moved up the neck. Index finger barres all 6 strings; fret number at left = root.




Major: fret 1=F, 2=F♯, 3=G, 5=A, 7=B, 8=C, 10=D… Minor: fret 1=Fm, 2=F♯m, 5=Am, 7=Bm…

## Barre Chords — A Shape (Major and Minor)

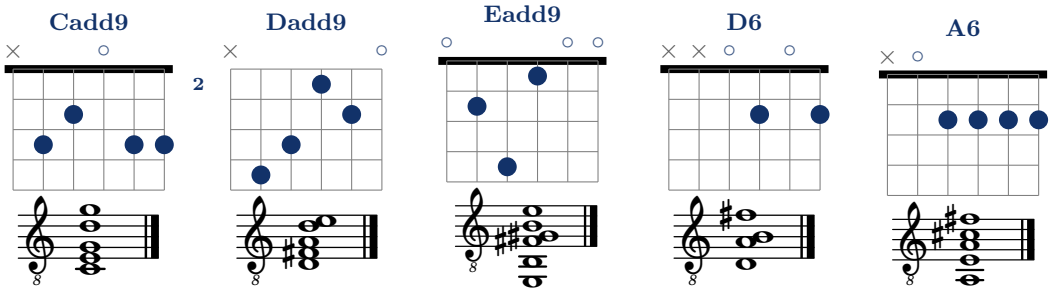
Open A or Am shape moved up the neck. Index finger barres strings 1–5.




Major: fret 1=B♭, 2=B, 3=C, 5=D, 7=E, 10=G… Minor: fret 1=B♭m, 2=Bm, 3=Cm, 5=Dm…

## Added-Tone Chords (add9, add6)

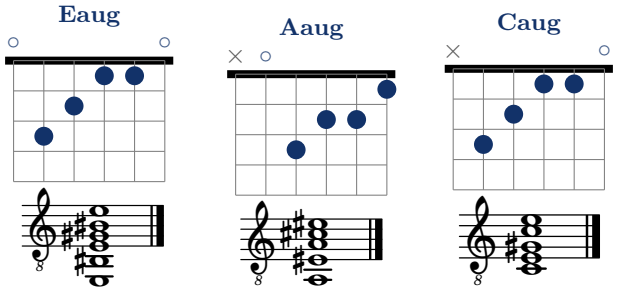
Triad + extra colour note (9th or 6th), without a 7th.




**Cadd9** x32033 **Dadd9** x54230 **Eadd9** 024100 **D6** xx0202 **A6** x02222

## Augmented Chords (aug)

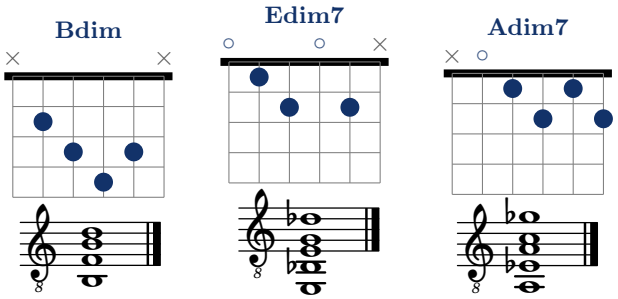
1 – 3 – ♯5: eerie and tense. Symmetrical — repeats every 4 semitones.




**Eaug** 032110 **Aaug** x03221 **Caug** x32110 Eaug = G♯aug = Caug (same pitch-class set).

## Diminished Chords (dim, dim7)

Stacked minor 3rds. A dim7 repeats every 3 semitones.




**Bdim** x2343x **Edim7** 01202x **Adim7** x01212 Shift a dim7 up 3 frets to get the same chord on a new root.

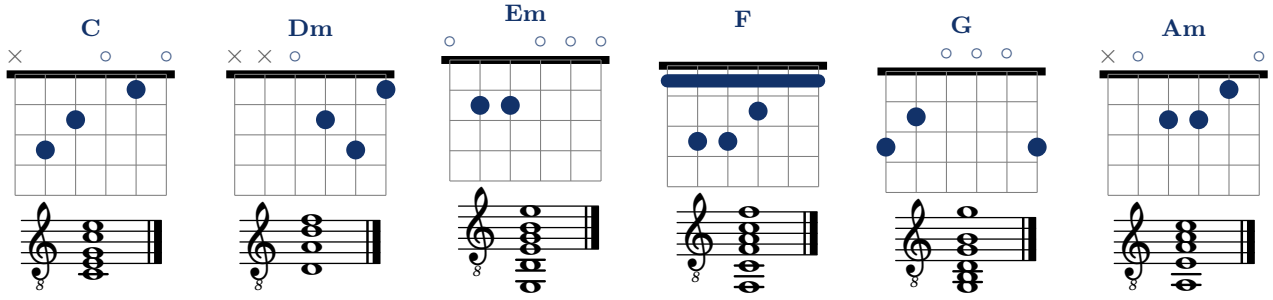
## Diatonic Chords and Roman Numeral Notation

Tonal music uses three complementary notation systems for chords. Being able to move between them is an essential skill:

| System | Description |
|---|---|
| **Chord name**(e.g. *G, Am, Dm*) | Gives the absolute pitch of the root and the chord quality (see the chord theory sections A–G). Useful for reading a chart or score. |
| **Scale degrees**(e.g. *1, ♭3, 5*) | Describes the *internal structure* of a chord regardless of key. Used in the formula tables of this guide. |
| **Roman numerals**(e.g. *I, IV, V, vi*) | Indicates the *position* of a chord within a given key: the numeral identifies the scale degree on which the chord is built. Upper case = major chord; lower case = minor chord; ° = diminished chord. Useful for transposing a progression to any key. |

### The seven diatonic chords of a major key

By stacking thirds on each degree of a major scale, we get seven chords whose qualities always follow the same pattern: **Maj – min – min – Maj – Maj – min – dim.** The table below shows all three notations for the key of **C major**:




| | I | ii | iii | IV | V | vi | vii° |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *C major* | C | Dm | Em | F | G | Am | Bdim |
| *G major* | G | Am | Bm | C | D | Em | F♯dim |
| *D major* | D | Em | F♯m | G | A | Bm | C♯dim |
| *A major* | A | Bm | C♯m | D | E | F♯m | G♯dim |
| *E major* | E | F♯m | G♯m | A | B | C♯m | D♯dim |

*How to use this table:* identify the Roman numeral pattern of a progression, then read across the row for the desired key. Example: **I – V – vi – IV** in C = C – G – Am – F; in G = G – D – Em – C; in D = D – A – Bm – G.

### Common progressions and their Roman numeral patterns

The progressions below appear in thousands of songs. The column *In C* gives the literal chord names; *Song* shows the actual key used in the recording.

| Roman pattern | In C | Song (key) | Feel |
|---|---|---|---|
| I – IV – V | C – F – G | La Bamba (C) | Bright, driving |
| I – V – vi – IV | C – G – Am – F | Let It Be (C) | Epic, universal |
| vi – IV – I – V | Am – F – C – G | Zombie (Em) | Melancholic, rock |
| i – VII – VI – VII | Am – G – F – G | All Along the Watchtower (C♯m) | Dramatic |
| I – V – vi – iii – IV | C – G – Am – Em – F | Pachelbel's Canon | Timeless, classical |
| ii – V – I | Dm – G – C | Jazz standard (C) | Tension→release |

## Chord Formula Quick Reference

| Symbol suffix | Formula | Semitone gaps | Character |
|---|---|---|---|
| (none) = Major | 1 – 3 – 5 | +4, +3 | Bright, stable |
| m = Minor | 1 – ♭3 – 5 | +3, +4 | Dark, melancholic |
| 7 = Dom. 7th | 1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 | +4, +3, +3 | Tense, bluesy |
| maj7 | 1 – 3 – 5 – 7 | +4, +3, +4 | Dreamy, jazzy |
| m7 | 1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 | +3, +4, +3 | Mellow, soulful |
| sus2 | 1 – 2 – 5 | +2, +5 | Open, floating |
| sus4 | 1 – 4 – 5 | +5, +2 | Tense, anticipating |
| 5 = Power | 1 – 5 | +7 | Raw, neutral |
| aug | 1 – 3 – ♯5 | +4, +4 | Eerie, tense |
| dim | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 | +3, +3 | Very tense |
| dim7 | 1 – ♭3 – ♭5 – ♭♭7 | +3,+3,+3 | Maximally tense |
| add9 | 1 – 3 – 5 – 9 | triad + 9th | Colourful, modern |
| 6 | 1 – 3 – 5 – 6 | triad + 6th | Sweet, vintage |

## Strumming and Rhythm Basics

**Strumming** is the act of sweeping the pick (or fingernails) across several strings at once to produce a chord. Two ingredients define a strumming pattern: the **time signature** (how beats are grouped) and the **stroke direction** (down or up) on each subdivision.

### Time signatures

| Sig. | Meaning | Feel / typical use |
|---|---|---|
| 4/4 | 4 beats per bar, quarter note = 1 beat | Most pop, rock, blues — the default |
| 3/4 | 3 beats per bar | Waltz, ballads (e.g. "Piano Man" by Billy Joel) |
| 6/8 | 6 eighth-note beats per bar, grouped 3+3 | Compound feel; suits fingerpicking (e.g. "House of the Rising Sun") |

### Stroke notation

Strumming patterns in this guide use the following symbols:

| Symbol | Meaning |
|---|---|
| **D** | Downstroke — sweep from string 6 (low E) toward string 1 (high e) |
| **U** | Upstroke — sweep from string 1 toward string 6 |
| **-** | Rest / lift — do not strike the strings on this subdivision |
| × | Choked strum — touch the strings with the palm or fretting hand to mute them just before or just as you strum |

### Counting subdivisions in 4/4

In 4/4 time, each beat can be divided into two eighth notes, counted **1 and 2 and 3 and 4 and**. Downstrokes fall on the numbered beats; upstrokes on the "ands":

| **1** | + | **2** | + | **3** | + | **4** | + |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **D** | U | **D** | U | **D** | U | **D** | U |

All-eighth pattern: the simplest full 4/4 strum.

### Common patterns

The table below shows the most widely used patterns. Each cell is one eighth-note subdivision ("1 + 2 + 3 + 4 +"). **Bold** = on-beat stroke; regular = off-beat ("and") stroke.

| Pattern name | Subdivisions: 1 + 2 + 3 + 4 + | | | | | | | | Used in |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| All down (4/4) | **D** | | **D** | | **D** | | **D** | | Folk, slow ballads |
| Basic 8ths | **D** | U | **D** | U | **D** | U | **D** | U | Pop, rock |
| Island | **D** | - | **D** | U | - | U | **D** | U | Horse With No Name, Wonderwall |
| Pop "4-chord" | **D** | U | **D** | U | - | U | **D** | U | Most pop |

*Reading tip:* always tap your foot on beats 1, 2, 3, 4. Downstrokes align with foot taps; upstrokes happen as the foot rises. Start very slowly with a metronome and only increase tempo once the pattern is automatic.

### Dynamics and accents

A flat sequence of D and U strokes sounds mechanical. Two techniques add life:

- **Accent beats 2 and 4.** In most Western popular music, the snare drum lands on beats 2 and 4 (the "backbeat"). Strumming those beats slightly harder locks you in with a drummer.
- **Vary string coverage.** Downstrokes can sweep all six strings for power, while upstrokes often catch only the top two or three — this lightens the texture and makes changes feel more natural.

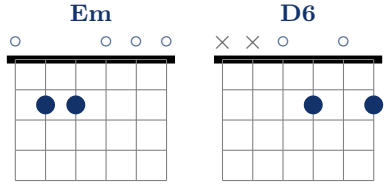
## Songs to Play

The four songs below cover progressively harder ground. Each entry shows the chord diagrams, then a bar-by-bar progression grid, then the strumming or picking pattern and a focused playing tip. **D** = downstroke, **U** = upstroke, **-** = rest, × = choked strum.

### 1. Horse With No Name — America (1971)

Level: beginner

Only two chords, repeated throughout. **Em** and **D6** alternate every two bars. Key: E minor.




**Progression** (same for intro, verse and chorus):

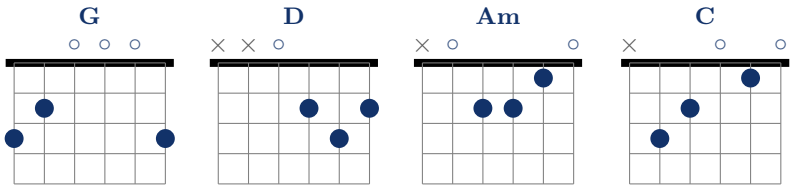
| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Em** | **Em** | **D6** | **D6** |

**Strumming** (4/4, ≈120 bpm): `D - D U - U D U`
**Tip:** Both chords use fret 2 only — Em on strings 5 and 4, D6 on strings 3 and 1 — and string 2 rings open in both. Leave strings 6 and 5 silent on D6. Keep the wrist relaxed.

### 2. Knockin' on Heaven's Door — Bob Dylan (1973)

Level: beginner

Two phrases in G major: **I – V – ii**, then **I – V – IV** (see "Diatonic Chords and Roman Numeral Notation": G – D – Am, then G – D – C). Four open chords; verse and chorus use the same sequence.




**Verse & Chorus:**

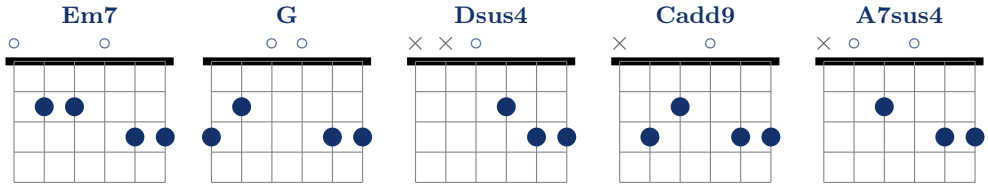
| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **G** | **D** | **Am** | **Am** |
| **G** | **D** | **C** | **C** |

**Strumming** (4/4, ≈68 bpm): `D - D - D U D U`
**Tip:** From G to D, the ring finger slides from string 1 to string 2 and stays on fret 3: place it first, then let the other fingers follow.

### 3. Wonderwall — Oasis (1995)

Level: intermediate

Famous for the **Cadd9** chord ("the Oasis chord") that recurs throughout. Key: F♯ minor (capo fret 2 recommended to play the open shapes as on the recording).




**Verse:**

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Em7** | **G** | **Dsus4** | **A7sus4** |

**Chorus:**

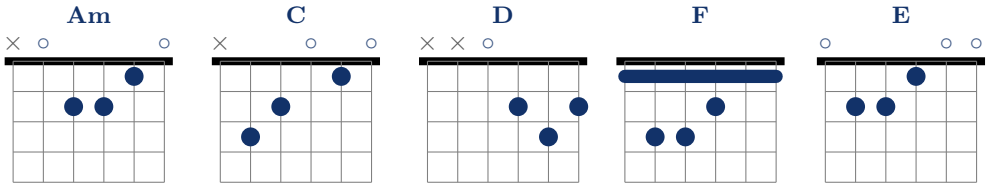
| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Cadd9** | **Em7** | **G** | **Em7** |

**Strumming** (4/4, ≈86 bpm): `D - D U - U D U`
**Tip:** These are the song's own shapes, not the standard open chords: fingers 3 and 4 stay on strings 2 and 1, both at fret 3, in all five chords; only fingers 1 and 2 change position.

### 4. House of the Rising Sun — The Animals (1964)

Level: intermediate

The iconic 6/8 fingerpicking piece. Progression **i – III – IV – VI** in A minor (Am – C – D – F; see "Diatonic Chords"). One chord per bar.



**Progression:**

| Am | C | D | F | Am | C | E | E |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|

**Fingerpicking** (6/8, ≈75 bpm): six notes per bar, starting on the string of the root — 5 for Am and C, 4 for D, 6 for F and E — and climbing toward string 1, e.g. `5 - 4 - 3 - 2 - 1 - 2` on Am.
**Tip:** Leave the strings below the root silent: string 6 on Am and C, strings 6 and 5 on D. For the F barre chord, first place fingers 2–4 on strings 3–5, then roll the index finger into the barre once the other fingers are set.

## Practice Tips

1. **Clean fretting.** Place the fingertip just *behind* the fret wire, pressing with the very tip.
2. **Thumb behind the neck.** Keep the thumb roughly opposite the middle finger so fretting fingers can arch cleanly.
3. **Muted strings.** Brush the string lightly with a neighbouring finger, or train the picking hand to avoid it.
4. **Barre chords.** Roll the index finger toward the headstock so the bony edge contacts the strings. Start at fret 5 where tension is lower, then work toward the nut.
5. **Anchor fingers.** When changing chords, keep fingers that stay on the same string/fret anchored while repositioning the rest.
6. **Slow practice.** Use a metronome. Master each transition cleanly at a slow tempo before increasing speed.
7. **Essential beginner progressions:** G – C – D | C – Am – F – G | Am – F – C – G | E – A – B7 – E.

All voicings in standard tuning (E A D G B e). TAB: 6 digits, low E first (0 = open, x = mute). Staff: treble-8 clef (guitar sounds one octave below written).